

Lecture 2: Asymptotic Analysis, Recurrences

Michael Dinitz

September 3, 2026
601.433/633 Introduction to Algorithms

Course changes and updates

Homeworks now released and due on Thursdays!

- ▶ HW1 released Sep 10, due Sep 17 at 11:59pm
- ▶ Makes more sense with office hours and lecture schedule.
- ▶ Note: probably HW due on fall break (Oct 22)!
- ▶ Oral presentations will be on Th/F

Office hours will be finalized soon (early next week)

- ▶ Prof. Dinitz office hours: Th 11am-12pm
- ▶ Prof. Sorrell office hours: sometime Wednesday (probably 11am-12pm)
- ▶ CA office hours: likely M-Th, 6pm-9pm
- ▶ TA Shruthi Prusty office hours: TBD

Today

Should be review, some might be new.

See math background in CLRS.

Asymptotics: $O(\cdot)$, $\Omega(\cdot)$, and $\Theta(\cdot)$ notation.

- ▶ Should know from Data Structures / MFCS. We'll be a bit more formal.
- ▶ Intuitively: hide constants and lower-order terms, since we only care what happens “at scale” (asymptotically).

Recurrences: How to solve recurrence relations.

- ▶ Should know from MFCS / Discrete Math.

Asymptotic Notation

$O(\cdot)$

Definition

$g(n) \in O(f(n))$ if there exist constants $c, n_0 > 0$ such that $g(n) \leq c \cdot f(n)$ for all $n > n_0$.

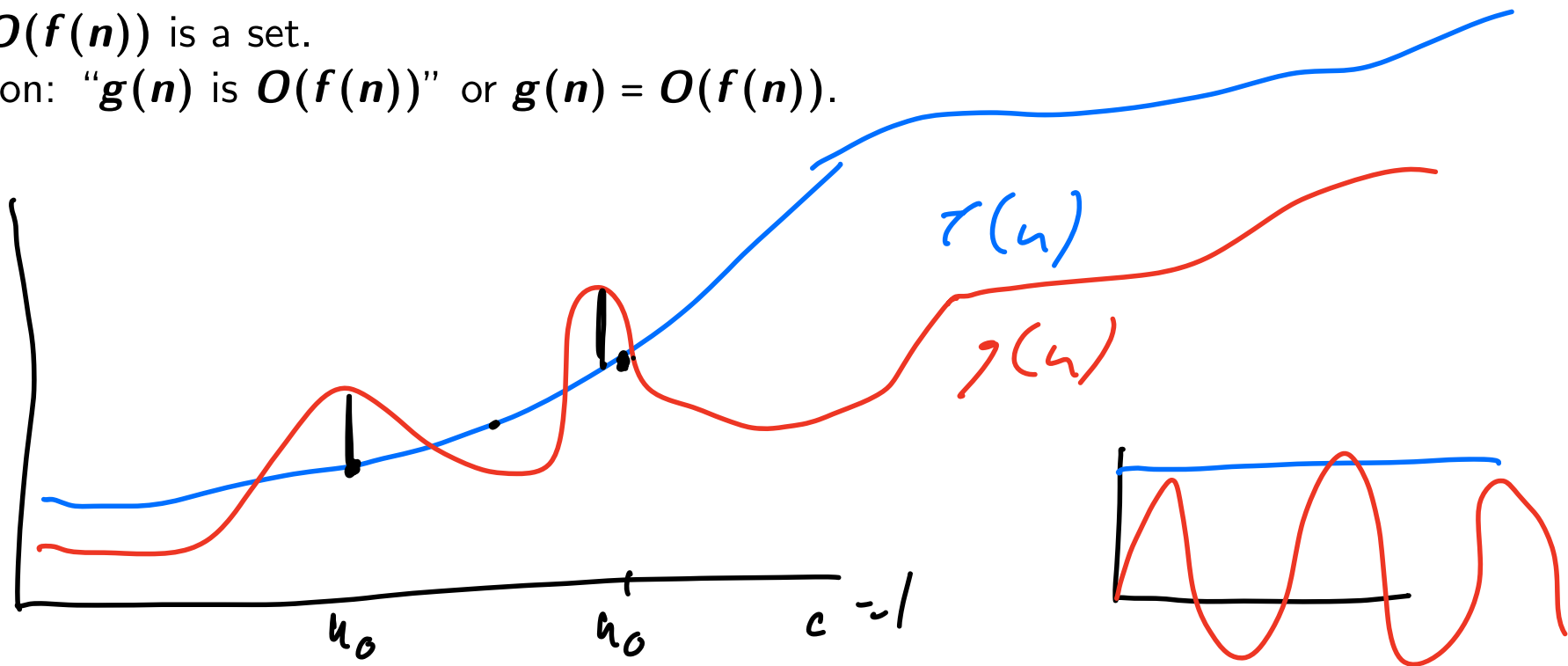
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Abuse notation: " $g(n)$ is $O(f(n))$ " or $g(n) = O(f(n))$."



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Examples:

- ▶ $2n^2 + 27 = O(n^2)$: set $n_0 = 6$ and $c = 3$
- ▶ $2n^2 + 27 = O(n^3)$: same values, or $n_0 = 4$ and $c = 1$
- ▶ $n^3 + 2000n^2 + 2000n = O(n^3)$: set $n_0 = 10000$ and $c = 2$

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About *functions*, not algorithms!

Expresses an *upper* bound.

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Theorem

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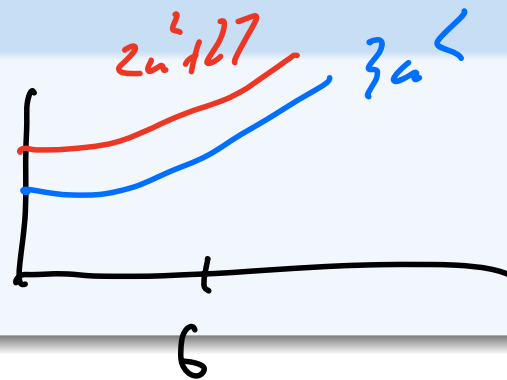
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Set $n_0 = 6$. Then $2n^2 + 27 \leq cn^2$ for all $n > n_0$.



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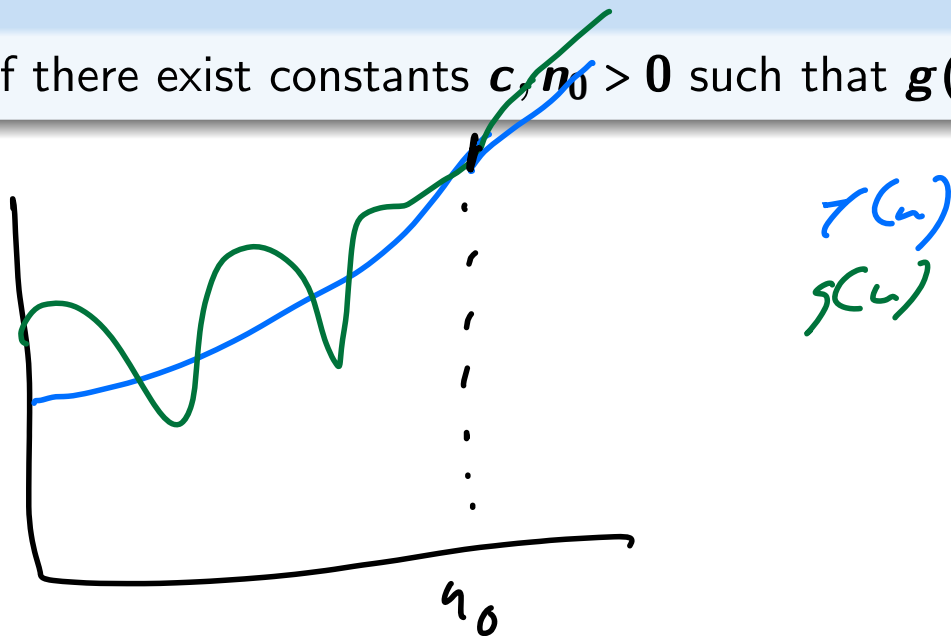
Many other ways to prove this!

$\Omega(\cdot)$

Counterpart to $O(\cdot)$: lower bound rather than upper bound.

Definition

$g(n) \in \Omega(f(n))$ if there exist constants $c, n_0 > 0$ such that $g(n) \geq c \cdot f(n)$ for all $n > n_0$.



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Examples:

- ▶ $2n^2 + 27 = \Omega(n^2)$: set $n_0 = 1$ and $c = 1$
- ▶ $2n^2 + 27 = \Omega(n)$: set $n_0 = 1$ and $c = 1$
- ▶ $\frac{1}{100}n^3 - 1000n^2 = \Omega(n^3)$: set $n_0 = 1000000$ and $c = 1/1000$

$\Theta(\cdot)$

Combination of $O(\cdot)$ and $\Omega(\cdot)$.

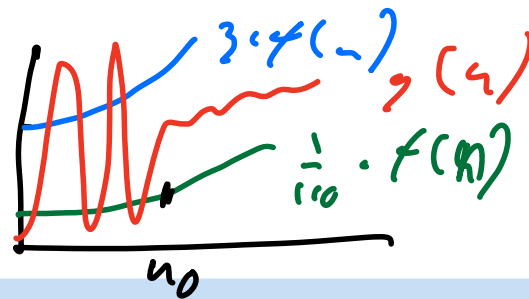
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Equivalently:

Definition

$g(n) \in \Theta(f(n))$ if there are constants $c_1, c_2, n_0 > 0$ such that $c_1 f(n) \leq g(n) \leq c_2 f(n)$ for all $n > n_0$.

Both lower bound and upper bound, so asymptotic equality.

Little notation

Strict versions of $\mathcal{O}$ and Ω :

Definition

$g(n) \in o(f(n))$ if for every constant $c > 0$ there exists a constant $n_0 > 0$ such that $g(n) < c \cdot f(n)$ for all $n > n_0$.

Definition

$g(n) \in \omega(f(n))$ if for every constant $c > 0$ there exists a constant $n_0 > 0$ such that $g(n) > c \cdot f(n)$ for all $n > n_0$.

Examples:

- ▶ $2n^2 + 27 = o(n^2 \log n)$
- ▶ $2n^2 + 27 = \omega(n)$

Recurrence Relations

Sorting

Many algorithms are recursive, so their running time is naturally a recurrence relation (Karatsuba, Strassen).

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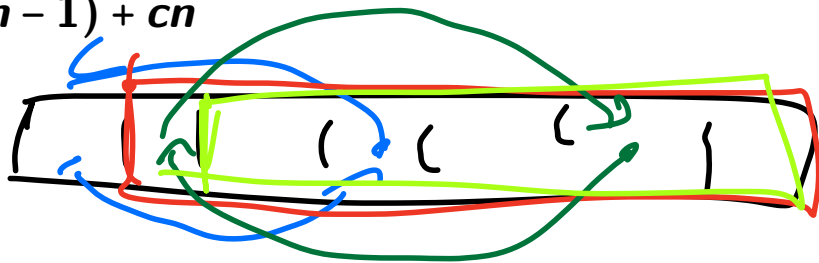
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$$\implies T(n) = T(n-1) + cn$$



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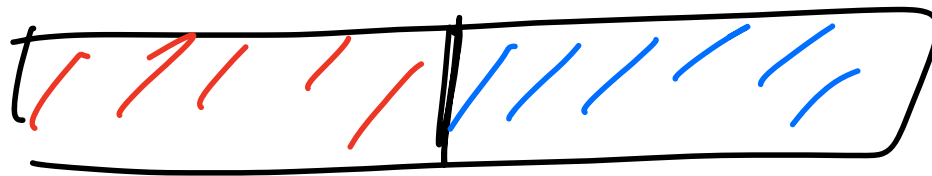
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- ▶ Split array into left and right halves. Recursively sort each half, then merge.



$$T(n) = 2T\left(\frac{n}{2}\right) + cn$$

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Also need base case. For algorithms, constant-size input takes constant time.

$\implies T(n) \leq c$ for all $n \leq n_0$, for some constants $n_0, c > 0$.

Guess and Check

$$T(n) = 3T(n/3) + n$$

$$T(1) = 1$$

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$$T(n) = 3T(n/3) + n \leq 3cn/3 + n = (c+1)n$$

↑
def

↑
induction

↑
alg 1/2

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Guess: $T(n) \leq n \log_3(3n)$

$$T(n) \leq n \cdot \log_3(n)$$

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$$\begin{aligned} T(n) &\stackrel{\text{def}}{=} 3T(n/3) + n \stackrel{\text{induction}}{\leq} 3(n/3) \log_3(3(n/3)) + n \stackrel{\text{use 1}}{=} n \log_3(n) + n \\ &\stackrel{\text{alg 6.2}}{=} n(\log_3(n) + \log_3 3) \stackrel{\text{log 3}}{=} n \log_3(3n). \end{aligned}$$

Unrolling

Example: selection sort. $T(n) = T(n - 1) + cn$

Idea: “unroll” the recurrence.

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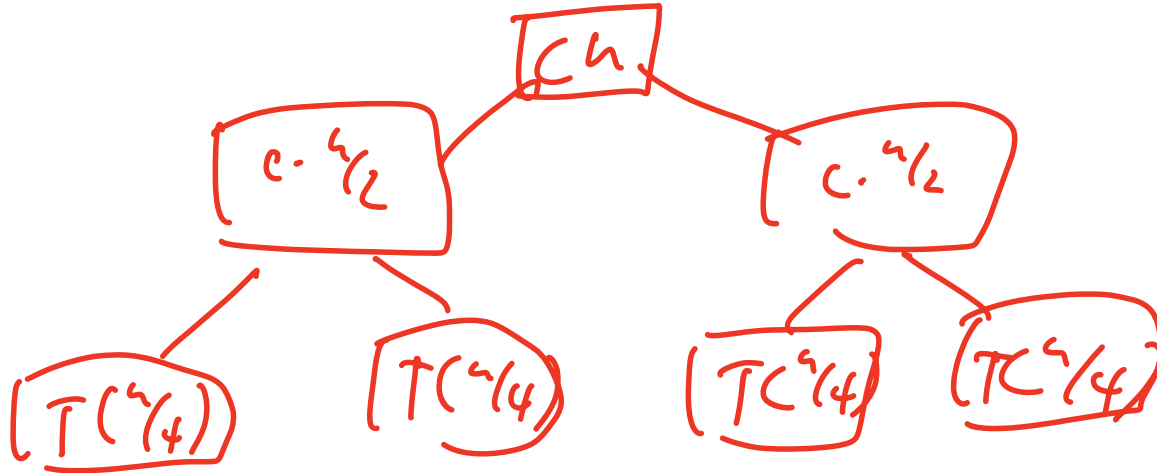
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Recursion Tree: Mergesort

Generalizes unrolling: draw out full tree of “recursive calls”.

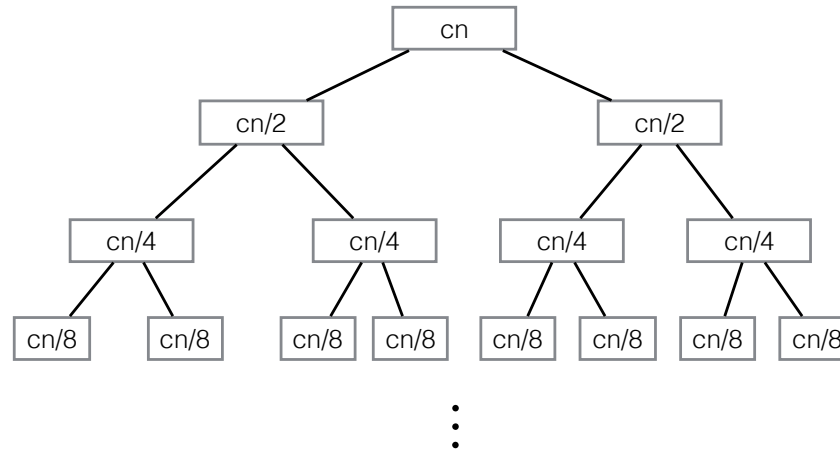
Mergesort: $T(n) = 2T(n/2) + cn$.



Recursion Tree: Mergesort

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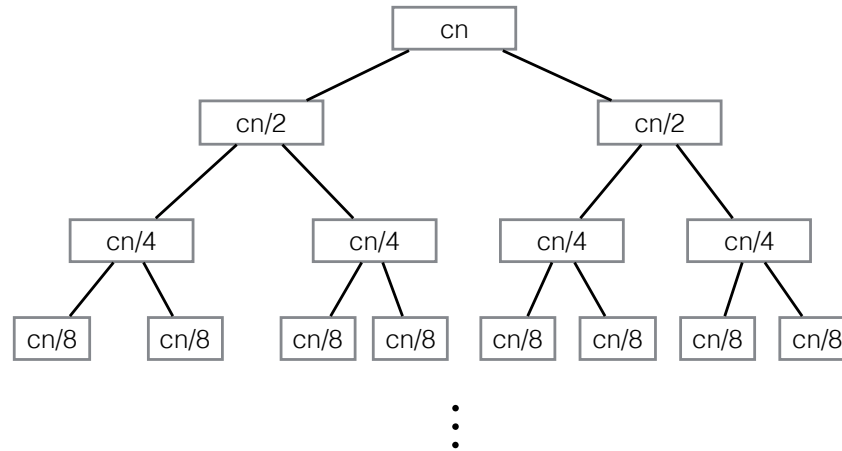
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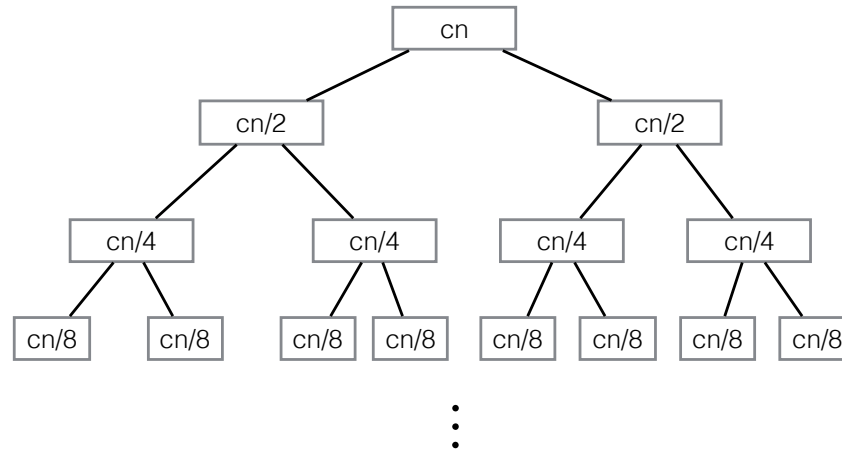


levels:

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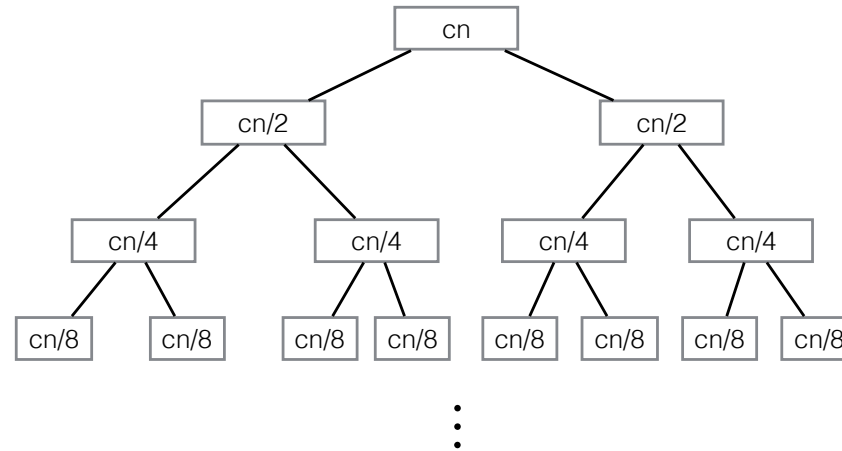


levels: $\log_2 n$

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cn

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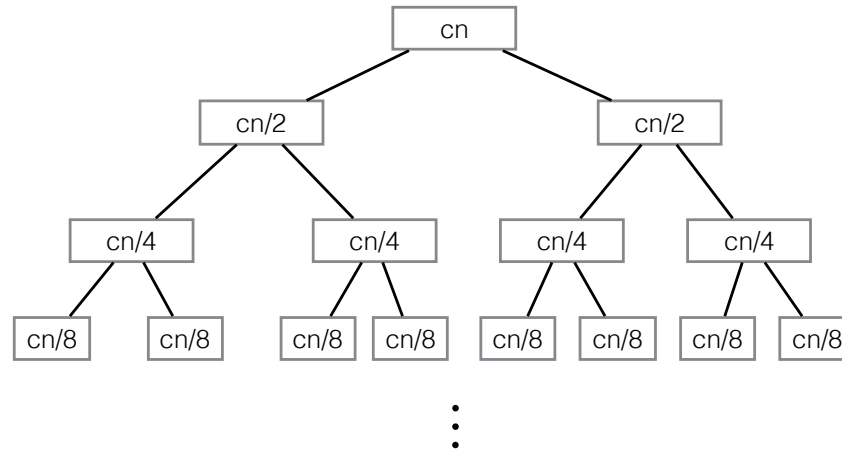
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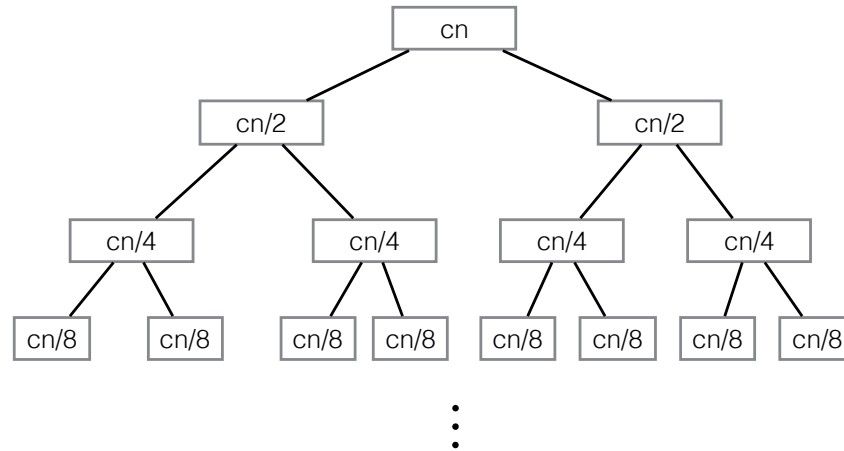
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Contribution of level i : $2^{i-1} cn/2^{i-1} = cn$

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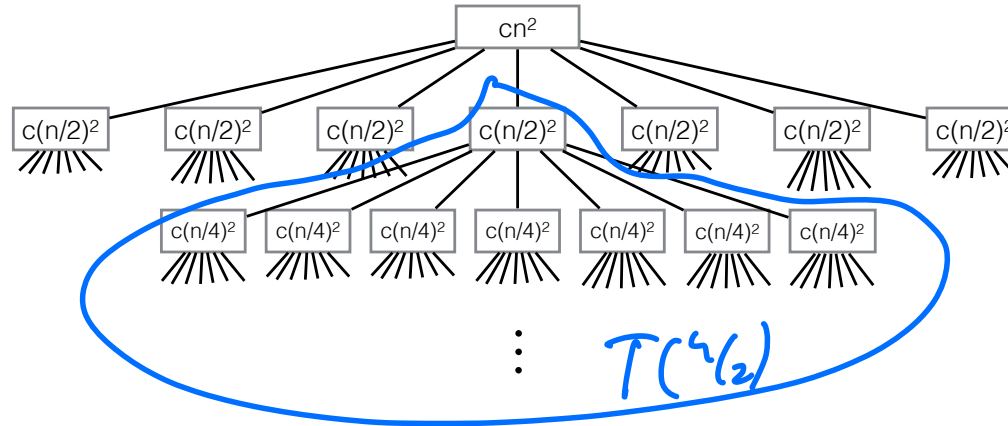
$\implies T(n) = \Theta(n \log n)$

Recursion Tree: Strassen

$$T(n) = 7T(n/2) + cn^2$$

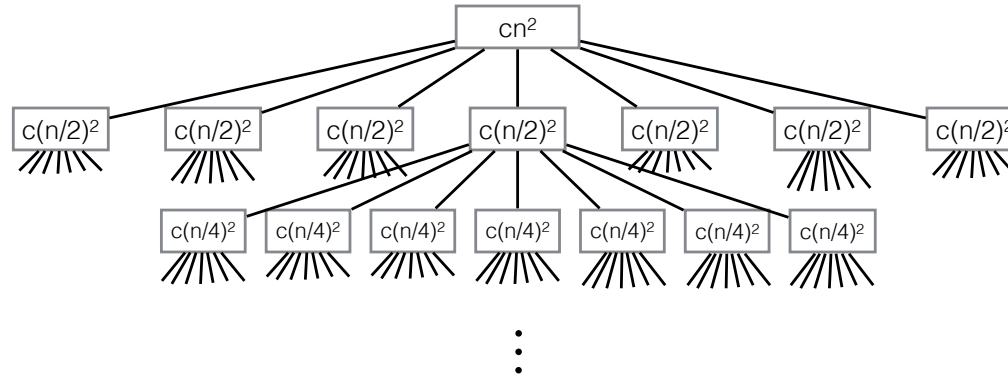
Recursion Tree: Strassen

$$T(n) = 7T(n/2) + cn^2$$



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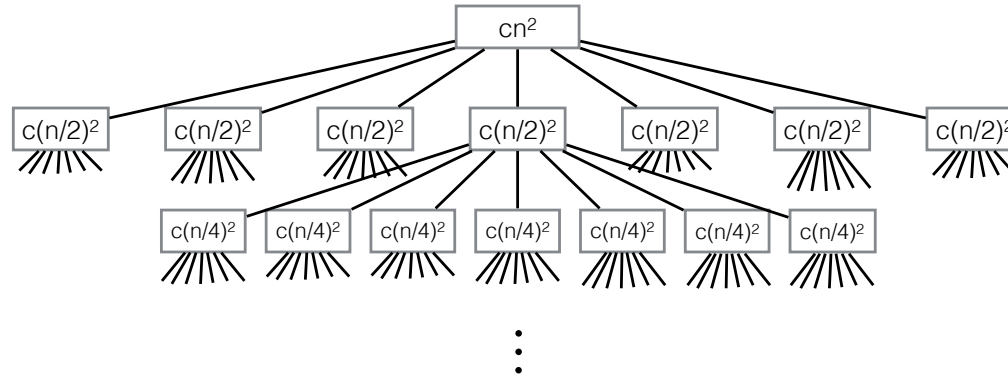


$$cn^2$$
$$7 \cdot c \cdot \frac{n^2}{4} = \frac{7}{4} \cdot cn^2$$

$$\text{Level } i: 7^{i-1}c(n/2^{i-1})^2 = (7/4)^{i-1}cn^2$$

Recursion Tree: Strassen

$$T(n) = 7T(n/2) + cn^2$$



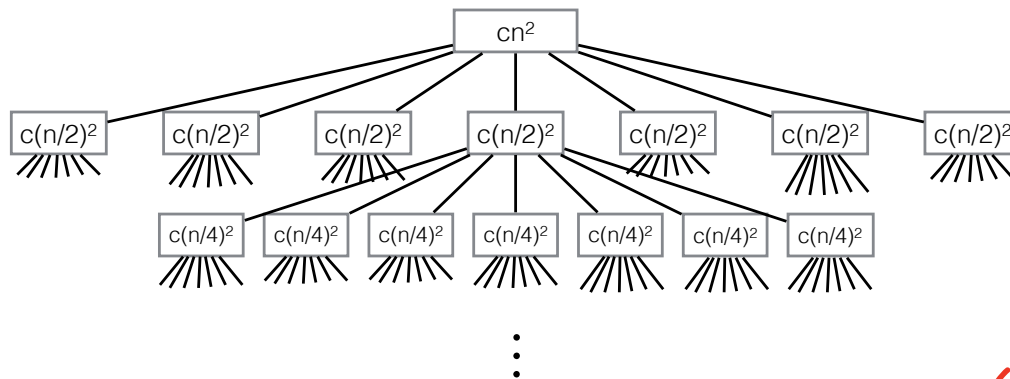
Level i : $7^{i-1}c(n/2^{i-1})^2 = (7/4)^{i-1}cn^2$

$$T(n) = \sum_{i=1}^{\log n+1} \left(\frac{7}{4}\right)^{i-1} cn^2 = cn^2 \sum_{i=1}^{\log n+1} \left(\frac{7}{4}\right)^{i-1}$$

Total:

Recursion Tree: Strassen

$$T(n) = 7T(n/2) + cn^2$$



Level i : $7^{i-1}c(n/2^{i-1})^2 = (7/4)^{i-1}cn^2$

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Total:

$$\begin{aligned} \Rightarrow T(n) &= O(n^2 (7/4)^{\log n}) = O(n^2 n^{\log(7/4)}) = O(n^2 n^{\log 7 - 2}) \\ &= O(n^{\log 7}) \end{aligned}$$

$\leq c' \cdot \left(\frac{7}{4}\right)^{\log n}$

Master Theorem

$$T(n) = aT(n/b) + cn^k \qquad T(1) = c$$

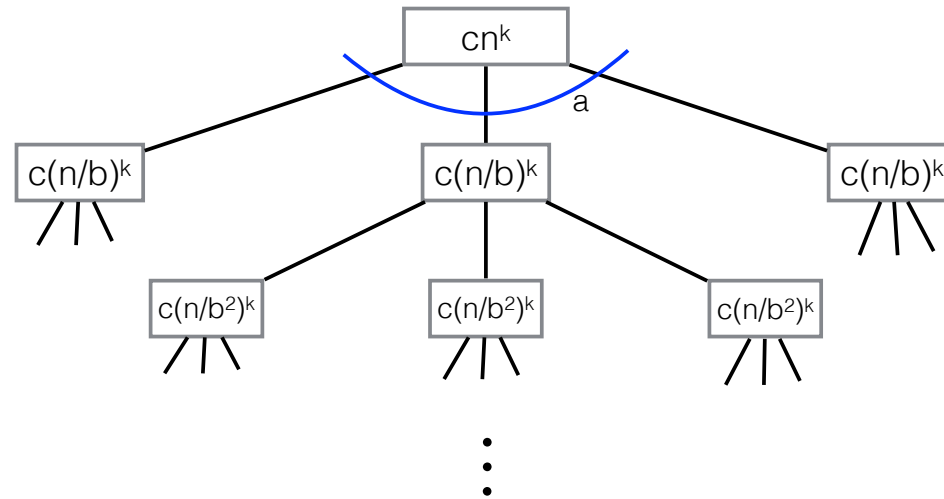
a, b, c, k constants with **$a \geq 1$** , **$b > 1$** , **$c > 0$** , and **$k \geq 0$**

Master Theorem

$$T(n) = aT(n/b) + cn^k$$

$$T(1) = c$$

a, b, c, k constants with $a \geq 1$, $b > 1$, $c > 0$, and $k \geq 0$

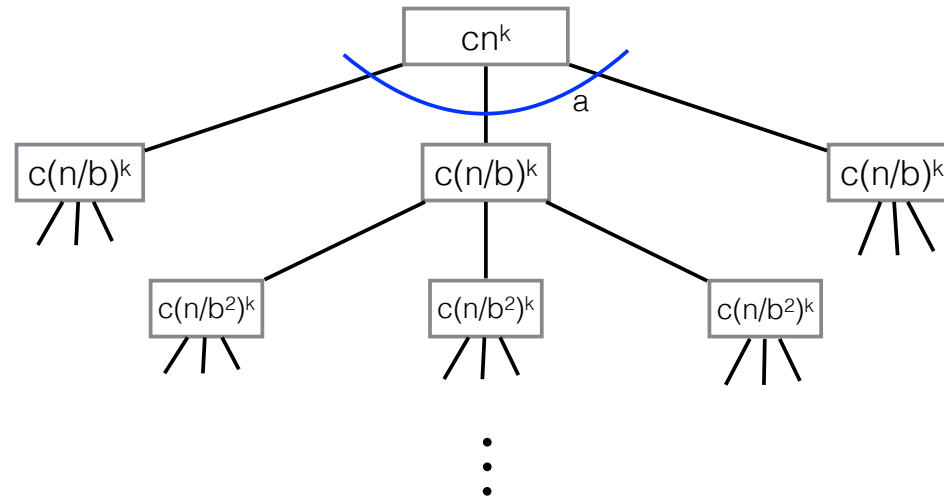


Master Theorem

$$T(n) = aT(n/b) + cn^k$$

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a, b, c, k constants with $a \geq 1$, $b > 1$, $c > 0$, and $k \geq 0$



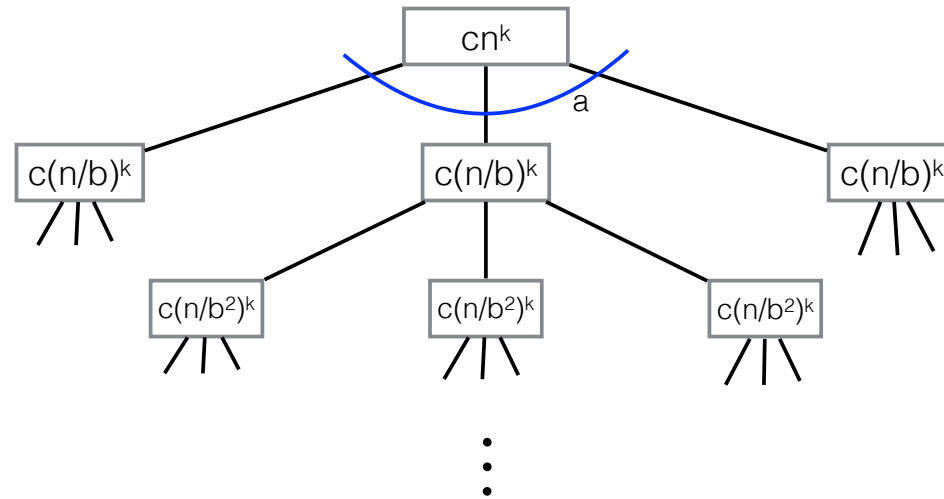
levels: $\log_b n + 1$

Master Theorem

$$T(n) = aT(n/b) + cn^k$$

$$T(1) = c$$

a, b, c, k constants with $a \geq 1$, $b > 1$, $c > 0$, and $k \geq 0$



levels: $\log_b n + 1$

Level i : $a^{i-1}c(n/b^{i-1})^k = cn^k(a/b^k)^{i-1}$

Master Theorem II

Let $\alpha = (a/b^k)$

$$\implies T(n) = cn^k \sum_{i=1}^{\log_b n+1} (a/b^k)^{i-1} = cn^k \sum_{i=1}^{\log_b n+1} \alpha^{i-1}$$

Master Theorem II

Let $\alpha = (a/b^k)$

$$\implies T(n) = cn^k \sum_{i=1}^{\log_b n+1} (a/b^k)^{i-1} = cn^k \sum_{i=1}^{\log_b n+1} \alpha^{i-1}$$

- ▶ Case 1: $\alpha = 1$. All levels the same. $T(n) = cn^k \sum_{i=1}^{\log_b n+1} 1 = \Theta(n^k \log n)$

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- ▶ Case 2: $\alpha < 1$. Dominated by top level.

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$$\implies \sum_{i=1}^{\log_b n+1} \alpha^{i-1} \leq \sum_{i=1}^{\infty} \alpha^{i-1} = \frac{1}{1-\alpha}.$$

$$\implies T(n) = O(n^k)$$

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$$T(n) \geq cn^k \implies T(n) = \Omega(n^k)$$

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▶ Case 3: $\alpha > 1$. Dominated by bottom level.

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► Case 1: $\alpha = 1$. All levels the same. $T(n) = cn^k \sum_{i=1}^{\log_b n+1} 1 = \Theta(n^k \log n)$

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$$T(n) \geq cn^k \implies T(n) = \Omega(n^k) \implies T(n) = \Theta(n^k)$$

► Case 3: $\alpha > 1$. Dominated by bottom level.

$$\begin{aligned} \implies \sum_{i=1}^{\log_b n+1} \alpha^{i-1} &= \alpha^{\log_b n} \sum_{i=1}^{\log_b n+1} \left(\frac{1}{\alpha}\right)^{i-1} \leq \alpha^{\log_b n} \frac{1}{1 - (1/\alpha)} \\ &= O(\alpha^{\log_b n}) \end{aligned}$$

Master Theorem II

Let $\alpha = (a/b^k)$

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$$T(n) \geq cn^k \implies T(n) = \Omega(n^k) \implies T(n) = \Theta(n^k)$$

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$$\implies \sum_{i=1}^{\log_b n+1} \alpha^{i-1} = \alpha^{\log_b n} \sum_{i=1}^{\log_b n+1} \left(\frac{1}{\alpha}\right)^{i-1} \leq \alpha^{\log_b n} \frac{1}{1 - (1/\alpha)}$$

$$= O(\alpha^{\log_b n})$$

$$\begin{aligned} \implies T(n) &= \Theta(n^k \alpha^{\log_b n}) = \Theta(n^k (a/b^k)^{\log_b n}) = \Theta(a^{\log_b n}) \\ &= \Theta(n^{\log_b a}) \end{aligned}$$

Master Theorem III

Theorem (“Master Theorem”)

The recurrence

$$T(n) = aT(n/b) + cn^k$$

$$T(1) = c$$

where a, b, c , and k are constants with $a \geq 1$, $b > 1$, $c > 0$, and $k \geq 0$, satisfies

$$T(n) = \begin{cases} \Theta(n^k) & \text{if } a < b^k, \\ \Theta(n^k \log n) & \text{if } a = b^k, \\ \Theta(n^{\log_b a}) & \text{if } a > b^k. \end{cases}$$